

AI & CONTROL | Machine vs Mankind: Agentic AI & the Battle for Human Agency

MEREDITH WHITTAKER
President, Signal Foundation

We are in a golden age of data collection and surveillance. AI models are finding patterns and identifying people across these troves of data

We are not saying 'no AI'. We are saying, recognise the consequences of short-term decisions on the back of long-term security and privacy

A GUARDRAIL FOR AI

Who controls the AI world? According to Meredith Whittaker, president of Signal Foundation, the non-profit that runs Signal Messenger, the answer to that question must go back to the 1990s when the Internet was born out of American university and government infrastructure that slowly went over to private companies without guardrails. At the India Today conclave, she spoke about how the companies at the forefront of AI development today are the same ones who started the Internet revolution, giving them extraordinary leeway over our future. They have "the authority to tell our stories for us, to define us, our reality, our worlds, in ways that don't map to traditional data privacy arguments," she said.

Signal, according to Whittaker, remains one of the few messaging apps that does not store any data of its users, unable to help even law enforcement agencies when they ask for it. "I make no money when you use Signal," said Whittaker. But, of course, vulnerabilities remain: even the most privacy-oriented applications run on operating systems like Windows or macOS, which can be hacked by bad actors. On top of that, agentic AI systems that access your private data are the "nightmare of cyber security professionals," she said. "They are extremely vulnerable."

"What we have here," Whittaker went on to say, "is a very uneasy tension in which the amount of investment that has been allocated to these extremely expensive AI models and infrastructure is pushing a lot of companies to introduce the technology in ways that are bypassing traditional cyber security safeguards or safety engineering." The way out: hitting the pause button, not on AI, but reckless deployment. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **AI needs your calendar and credit card details to plan a trip or book a car for you. These are vectors for invasion of privacy**
- **Governments can't collect or distribute the amount of data that private companies can across borders**
- **Sensitive data is being bought and sold by data brokers to hasten AI development**

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